They are apt to mislead to-day when they are associated with a much narrower, and specifically religious, concept. T h e word ' H i n d u ' does not occur at all in our ancient literature. T h e first reference to it in an Indian book is, I am told, in a *Tantrik* work of the eighth century **A.C**., where ' H i n d u ' means a people and not the followers of a particular religion. But it is clear that the word is a very old one, as it occurs in the Avesta and in old Persian. It was used then and for a thousand years or more later by the peoples of western and central Asia for India, or rather for the people living on the other side of the Indus river. T h e word is clearly derived from Sindhu, the old, as well as the present, I n d i a n name for the Indus. From this Sindhu came the words Hindu a n d Hindustan, as well as Indus and India.

T h e famous Chinese pilgrim I-tsing, who came to India in the seventh century A.c., writes in his record of travels that the 'northern tribes', that is the people of Central Asia, called India ' H i n d u ' (Hsin-tu) but, he adds, 'this is not at all a common n a m e . .. and the most suitable name for India is the Noble L a n d (Aryadesha).' T h e use of the word ' H i n d u ' in connection with a particular religion is of very late occurrence.